

Takaa Awori, *Leadership in Africa Redefined*

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Chapter Two

DRIVEN BY PURPOSE

Don't set out to be a leader. Set out to make a difference.

—Angela Dwamena-Aboagye

Executive Director of the Ark Foundation

BETWEEN 1994 AND 2001, thirty-four women were brutally murdered in Ghana under mysterious circumstances. Feeling frustrated that the government was not doing enough to find the culprits behind these murders, women from a wide cross-section of society came together to protest. Angela Dwamena-Aboagye was one of those women.

One day, these women, who were now calling themselves the Sisters' Keepers, decided to meet in front of the police headquarters, dressed in red and black, the traditional colours of mourning in Ghana. The plan was for the women to convene in front of the building, sit in the street and weep with their hands on their heads. Angela was a little late because she had been making a banner at home. When she finally arrived, everybody was saying, "We've been waiting for you for the last half hour now. Where have you been?" Angela was thinking, "Why should you be waiting for me? I mean, we are all in this together." But she could see the anxiety on their faces when they said, "We've been waiting for you all this while so that we can take the next steps." At that moment, it dawned on Angela: the other women saw her as one of the leaders of the campaign. The truth was that Angela did not set out to be a campaign leader; rather, she set out to demand justice for the murdered women.

The most impactful leaders on this continent do not set out to be leaders; they set out to make a difference. Even though they often end up with formal leadership positions, it is clear that getting a title or position is not what drives them. Angela, for example, has gone on to occupy many other formal leadership positions, such as Founder and Executive Director of The Ark Foundation, one of Ghana's leading organisations working on violence against women and children. It is clear that her leadership is driven by her quest to make a difference in the lives of women. A desire to create change will bring leadership into your life; however, wanting to be a leader for the position and title does not always mean you will bring about change.

Another leader on this continent who did not set out to gather titles but rather, make a difference is Moussoukoro Diop. This young Senegalese computer Engineer is one of Africa's leading social media influencers with large following on Twitter, Facebook, and Instagram. What is so admirable about Moussou is how she uses her influence to make a difference. She is actively involved in campaigns that promote the rights of women and girls, and advocate for the involvement of more girls in ICT in Africa. She also promotes Senegal as a beautiful destination for visitors. More recently, Moussou has used her influence to raise awareness, sharing current information on COVID-19 in Senegal.

Another example is Eldine Chilembe Glees. Eldine was among the first female cadets in the nascent maritime industry in Angola. Her decision to enter such a male-dominated industry was purely because she wanted to make a difference. In a casual conversation one day, her sister mentioned that the maritime industry in Angola had little to no known active women. There and then, Eldine, thanking her sister, said, “Looks like I don’t have a choice. Challenge accepted.”

Eldine became one of three women who gained a maritime scholarship based at Sonatide in Angola. Her first test was just before they offered her the scholarship, when they asked her to go on the ship for about a week. She told herself that if it turned out to be a great fit, good, and if not, she would turn around and count it as a great experience, nothing lost. The moment Eldine boarded the vessel, she knew instantly that this was where she needed and wanted to be. She couldn’t imagine anything else than being a maritime officer.

Initially, she wanted to specialise in maritime engineering, but lots of the captains kept referring to her as leadership material, so she chose the path of a navigating officer. She went to a maritime school in Cape Town. In the university, Eldine would interview officers who had come back from the sea to know why very few women joined and remained in the maritime industry. What were the hindering factors? Why were they not progressing as well as the male officers? This marked the beginning of her goal to advocate for female employment and promotion in the maritime sector.

Due to her love for the course, Eldine put a lot into her studies, spent time with the teachers on their projects, etc. The dean would nominate her as an ambassador for the international maritime conferences held at the school. She received the Dean’s Excellence Award and graduated Cum Laude. Eldine shared that one of her friends asked her if she thought she could be a leader during that time at the Maritime Academy. The immediate answer was a blunt “No.” She didn’t see herself as a leader. All she sought was to make a difference by treading on a path that few women had ventured to walk through.

For this reason, when I meet people in leadership positions, I sometimes ask myself, “What drives this person?” The answer to this question tells me how impactful they are as leaders. If what seems to be driving them is the promotion, the prestige, the power, or the influence, then I know the impact of their leadership will be limited. If it’s about achieving a goal bigger than themselves, such as creating a better community, or a thriving business that provides a valuable service to its customers, then I know the impact of that leadership will be more positive.

The truth is, we are all human. Our egos seek leadership positions to make us feel worthy. We often tell ourselves that our importance as human beings comes from having an “important” position. And in Africa, where hierarchy is king and deference is showered generously on those with titles, it is no surprise that many seek leadership positions for all the wrong reasons. Indeed, the privileges and perks of many leadership positions in Africa can give unsuspecting leaders amnesia, where they forget that it is not about them but about what they do for others.

Even when you seek a leadership position for all the right reasons, leadership can be hard. People will misunderstand you, you will be betrayed, and you will not always be able to keep people happy. In those moments, you might ask yourself whether leadership is worth it. Your purpose will answer that question. Your purpose will remind you why you should stay in the game.

When I refer to purpose in this book, I mean the positive impact you are seeking to have in this world with your unique gifts. Using these unique gifts to make a difference lights you up. Your purpose may change over time, and it need not be static throughout your life. Furthermore, your purpose need not be as grand as ending world hunger. It could be large or small, but all that matters is that you're making a difference. As Mark Twain stated, "The two most important days in your life are the day you are born and the day you find out why."

Discovering your purpose is not easy. It requires self-development, what you stand for, what you unashamedly declare, and what you unapologetically pursue or fight for. This is not about following prescriptions handed to you about who you are and what you "should" be doing. It is about exploring what resonates with you and brings about movement in others through your interaction, influence, and inspiration.

Doing the inner work to clarify one's purpose comes from a place of self-worth and value. It comes from believing you are worthy and that you have unique gifts to give. It comes from confidence, knowing that you are not just a cog in the wheel. But the reality is, many leaders are products of an education system that taught them the opposite.

These are education systems whose colonial legacies are still palpable. Inherent in the colonial education was a valorisation of everything Western and European, and devaluation or deprioritisation of that which is African. So, I ask you, how can you find your purpose, your unique gifts when what is quintessentially you, your culture, your language, your history is rendered unworthy compared to that which is European?

Equally limiting has been the pedagogy of the education systems in most African countries, which Paulo Freire, the Brazilian educator, described as the "Banking" concept in his seminal work *Pedagogy of the Oppressed*.^[1] In this pedagogy, the minds of students are seen as empty accounts into which teachers deposit information.

The performance of students is not measured by their critical analysis of the information they receive but by their ability to memorise and regurgitate this information in exams. In Ghana, they refer to this as "chew and pour." This is in contrast to Friere's problem-posing education, which, as he states: "affirms men and women as beings in the process of becoming." In the problem-posing education, dialogue is used to awaken critical consciousness on behalf of the student.

This awakening creates a fertile ground for doing the inner work required to discover one's unique purpose. Without it, discovering purpose is not impossible; it is just a little harder.

Ultimately, purpose is an element that sets authentic transformative leaders apart from those who need to convince others of their leadership capabilities. Your purpose animates your leadership. It is this purpose that inspires followership and ultimately results.

So, if you are seeking to step into a leadership position or are currently in a leadership position, there are several questions you should ask yourself:

- What is my purpose?
- Why do I want to lead?

- What does leadership mean to me?
- What difference or impact do I want to make with my leadership?

Let us be reminded of the inspirational leaders who have walked before and among us. Leaders like Angela, Moussoukoro, and Eldine were passionate about making a difference. They had found their purpose. People follow these types of leaders not because they have to, but because they are inspired by the vision and model they provide.

[1] Freire, Paolo. *Pedagogy of the Oppressed*. Tr. Myra Bergman Ramos. New York: Continuum International Publishing Group, 1970.

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